Stage 1 Hypertension. Focus is on dietary modification (without drugs) to reduce excess weight and restrict sodium.

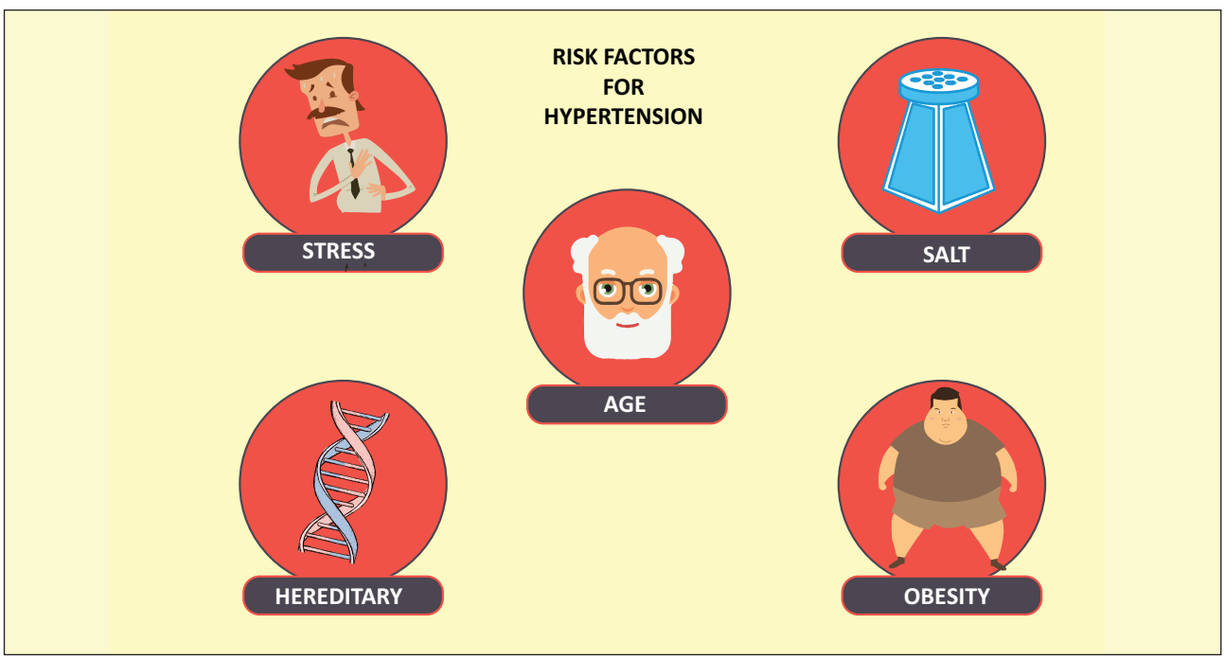
Stage 2 Hypertension. In addition to the diet therapy for stage 1, drugs are used according to need and usually include a diuretic agent. Continious use of some, diuretic drugs cause loss of potassium along with the increased loss of water from the body. Potassium replacement becomes necessary to avoid irregular heart beat.

Stage 3 Hypertension. Vigorous drug therapy becomes necessary along with dietary changes in stage 2. Nutritional support is important for all types of hypertension, along with other nondrug therapies of physical exercise and stress reduction.

Risk factors for hypertension

Major risk factors are:

- **Smoking.** Smoking increases the heart's workload, raising blood pressure as nicotine in cigarette constricts the small blood vessels.
- **High blood lipids**. High blood lipids contribute to both atherosclerosis and hypertension.
- **Poor diet**. Diets rich in saturated fat and cholesterol with low intake of fruit and vegetable raises blood pressure.
- **Diabetes**. People with diabetes often have high blood pressure.
- **Gender**. Risk of blood pressure is higher in men than in-women and the risk is higher in post menopausal women.
- **Age**. Onset increases with advancing age (>60 years) as old age is associated with loss of elasticity of the arteries.
- **Heredity**. A family history of hypertension in women under 65 and in men under 55 significantly raises the risk of developing hypertension.
- **Obesity**. Excess body fat, especially abdominal fat, is closely associated with hypertension.
- **Lack of exercise**. Less active people are twice likely to develop hypertension than their active counterparts.



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